PassFrame
TUITION

The Great Fire of London

Year 4 — 11+ Lesson Worksheet (PassFrame Tuition)

Comprehension | Non-fiction (History)

Extract — read it carefully before answering

In the early hours of 2nd September 1666, a small fire broke out in a baker's shop on Pudding Lane in the city of London. Nobody could have guessed that, within days, it would destroy most of the city.

London at the time was the perfect place for a fire to spread. The streets were narrow, and most houses were built from wood and covered in tar, which caught alight easily. A strong wind that night carried sparks from roof to roof, turning the small kitchen fire into an unstoppable blaze.

For four days, the fire raged across the city. Thousands of people fled with whatever belongings they could carry, some escaping onto the River Thames in rowing boats to watch helplessly as their homes burned. Even the great cathedral of St Paul's, built from stone, was not safe — the heat was so intense that its roof eventually melted and collapsed.

Remarkably, official records suggest that only a handful of people died in the fire itself, although historians believe the true number may never be known for certain. Over 13,000 houses and 87 churches were destroyed, leaving tens of thousands of Londoners homeless.

After the fire, London was rebuilt with wider streets and buildings made from brick and stone instead of wood, making the city far safer from fire in the future. The architect Christopher Wren designed a new St Paul's Cathedral, which still stands proudly in London today.

Questions

20 min · 12 questions

1. On which date did the Great Fire of London begin?

2. Where did the fire first break out?

3. Underline the sentence that tells you why London's buildings caught fire so easily.

4. Underline the sentence that describes what happened to St Paul's Cathedral during the fire.

5. What does “raged” suggest about how the fire behaved over the four days?

6. True or false: historians are completely certain how many people died in the fire.

7. Why do you think a strong wind made the fire so much worse?

8. How many houses does the text say were destroyed?

9. In your own words, explain how London was made safer after the fire.

10. What does the phrase “watch helplessly” suggest about how people felt as their homes burned?

11. Why do you think the author included the exact numbers of houses and churches destroyed?

12. Do you think rebuilding London in brick and stone was a good decision? Explain your answer using evidence from the text.